Joy to the world

TRADITION IN EVERY SLICE

Sarah.John
@timesofindia.com

From its historical evolution to its place in contemporary celebrations, the Christmas cake remains an irreplaceable part of the season.

A DELICIOUS EVOLUTION

The Christmas cake as we know it evolved from Christmas pudding, that steamed British confection laden with dried fruits. Historical accounts suggest the transformation occurred gradually during the Victorian era, when baking technology improved and ovens became more reliable and widespread.

Christmas pudding, which is still popular in Britain and former colonies, was boiled or steamed, creating a dense, moist dessert that could be stored for months, even years. The cake version emerged as a baked alternative, using similar ingredients but creating a different texture and allowing for elaborate decoration.

The tradition migrated to various parts of the world, each region adapting it to local tastes and ingredients. In the city, the plum cake became so integral to celebration culture that it transcended its Christmas origins, appearing at weddings, anniversaries, and significant family occasions. This adaptation speaks to how deeply the cake embedded itself in local traditions.

THE ART OF SHARING

A Christmas cake is never meant to be eaten alone. Its rich nature makes it ideal for sharing. Families gather around slices after Christmas dinner. Visitors throughout the season are offered cake with tea or coffee. The cake becomes a vehicle for hospitality and connection.

"We bake multiple cakes every year," explains Annie Thevarthundil, a retired teacher. "One for our family, several for gifting. It's tradition—you give cake to neighbours, to friends, to colleagues. Receiving homemade Christmas cake feels special because you know the effort and care that went into it."

The gifting tradition serves multiple purposes. It maintains social bonds, expresses affection and goodwill, and shares the abundance of the season. A beautifully packaged Christmas cake carries more meaning than store-bought gifts—it represents time, skill, and genuine thoughtfulness.

DECORATING THE CROWN

The top of a Christmas cake offers a canvas for creativity. Traditional decoration involves a layer of marzipan followed by royal icing, creating a smooth white surface that can be further embellished. Modern decorations have expanded the possibilities considerably. Some prefer fondant, which allows for more elaborate sculpting and colour. Others opt for minimal icing, letting the dark cake peek through, perhaps with just a dusting of icing sugar and some decorative elements.

Toppings vary widely: candied fruits arranged in festive patterns, marzipan figures depicting Santa Claus, or simply crushed nuts for texture and visual interest.

"I keep the decoration simple—just a thin layer of icing and some dried fruits on top," says baker K S Thomas. "The cake itself is the star. The decoration should complement, it should not overwhelm the cake or affect the taste."

Not easy to make, but easy to eat. The Christmas cake or plum cake goes beyond Christmas festivities and features prominently in life events

THE SECRET SPICES

Every baker claims to know the 'secret' to the perfect Christmas cake, and often those secrets involve spices. The base typically includes cinnamon, nutmeg, and cloves—the holy trinity of Christmas baking. But variations abound.

Some add cardamom, particularly common in Indian versions, which contributes a distinctive warmth. "The spice blend is what makes each family's cake unique," notes Thomas. "We all use similar ingredients—flour, butter, eggs, dried fruits—but the spice ratios create completely different flavour profiles. That's the real secret."

The fruit mixture itself requires weeks of soaking, allowing flavours to meld and intensify. This preparation time is non-negotiable for authentic taste.

CUP CAKE STYLE

"I make Christmas cake cupcakes for corporate gifting," explains entrepreneur Smitha Francis. "They're perfectly portioned, look professional when packaged nicely, and people appreciate not having to deal with a whole cake." Christmas cake in individual portions has become increasingly popular. These miniature versions offer several advantages: easier portion control, convenient for gifting, no need to slice and serve, and the ability to create variety by decorating each differently.

CAKE VS YULE LOG

Christmas cake dominates in Britain, former British colonies, and regions with strong Anglo influence. However, in France and French-influenced areas, the Bûche de Noël or Yule log reigns supreme—a rolled sponge cake decorated to resemble a wooden log.

The yule log represents different traditions—the ancient practice of burning a large log throughout Christmas, symbolising warmth and continuity. The edible version emerged in 19th century France, quickly becoming a beloved tradition. Each has its adherents. Fruit cake lovers appreciate the density, richness, and improving flavour over time. Yule log enthusiasts prefer the lighter sponge, cream filling, and chocolate decoration.

THE CHALLENGE OF QUALITY

Finding quality Christmas cake for gifting presents genuine challenges. Mass-produced versions often rely on artificial flavours, excessive sweeteners, and insufficient fruit, creating cakes that lack the depth and character of traditional recipes. "The supermarket Christmas cakes are disappointing," admits Thevarthundil. "They look nice but taste artificial. Finding bakers who make traditional cakes with real ingredients and proper preparation time is difficult, and they're expensive."

The search for quality often leads back to homemade options. Families who maintain baking traditions find themselves in demand, their cakes requested by friends who've given up on commercial options.

MORE THAN CAKE

The Christmas cake represents continuity in changing times. Despite evolving tastes and modern conveniences, people maintain the tradition of baking, sharing, and enjoying these rich, spiced cakes. The effort involved stands in contrast to our instant-gratification culture.

Perhaps that's precisely why the tradition endures. In a world of shortcuts, the Christmas cake demands patience.

READER ENGAGEMENT INITIATIVE

Homes of the family, 'buy' the family

Families that invest together, thrive and more buyers are choosing to co-purchase homes with family. Here's why

Anisha.Sahijwala
@timesofindia.com

When 37-year-old Radhika Upadhyay decided to buy a two BHK flat, she didn't go solo. Instead, she co-invested with her parents—pooling resources, splitting responsibilities and jointly owning the property. Like her, many Indians are now co-investing in real estate with their parents and sharing ownership for a more secure future.

THE AFFORDABILITY FACTOR

Affordability is the most common consideration when buying a home with one's folks. With property prices steadily rising in urban centres and incomes not quite keeping pace with inflation, young individuals often find it challenging to purchase property independently. Co-purchasing helps share costs, boost loan eligibility, and unlocks better housing options. "Banks also look favourably at joint applications. Having parents as co-applicants—especially if they have a solid credit history—can boost one's chances of securing a property loan at competitive interest rates," notes Arvind Nandgaonkar, a real estate consultant.

Sharing EMIs with family eases the financial burden, making homeownership more manageable. It's especially helpful for those already balancing rent, lifestyle expenses, or education loans.

CULTURE AND COMFORT

Beyond the numbers, culture plays a key role, as there's a deeply entrenched tradition of family-centric decision-making when it comes to big-ticket investments. "In Indian culture, family wealth is often viewed as a shared legacy, encouraging the practice of joint investment," explains sociologist Meera Poojary. In multi-generational homes, co-investing deepens family bonds and shared accountability.

NOT WITHOUT CHALLENGES

Co-investing comes with several caveats. Issues related to ownership rights, inheritance, or future sale decisions can arise. Experts advice drawing up clear legal agreements, ideally with clauses that define sharing rights, exit plans and dispute mechanisms. As multi-generational living gains traction, this practice is becoming a strategic way to build lasting family wealth.

WISH YOU ALL
Merry Christmas & Happy New Year
ಶುಭಕೋರುವವರು: ರೆಕ್ಟರ್, ಪ್ರಾಂಶುಪಾಲರು, ಸಿಬ್ಬಂದಿ ವರ್ಗದವರು ಹಾಗೂ ವಿದ್ಯಾರ್ಥಿಗಳು

MYSORE DIOCESAN EDUCATIONAL SOCIETY (R)
ST. PHILOMENA'S COLLEGE
(Autonomous) Estd.:1946
Accredited by NAAC and Approved by AICTE, New Delhi
Mysore-Bangalore Highway, Bannimantap, Mysore-570 015

ADMISSIONS OPEN
FOR 2026 - 2027

PUC
SCIENCE
PCMB · PCMC · PCME · PCBH
COMMERCE: BASC · EGBA
ARTS: HEGP · HESP

B.A. Programmes
Economics, History, Political Sc., Sociology, Optional English, Christianity, Psychology, Journalism & Mass Communication, Criminology & Forensic Science

B.Sc. Programmes
Physics, Chemistry, Mathematics, Botany, Zoology, Computer Science, Biotechnology, Microbiology, Food Science and Nutrition Biochemistry, Criminology & Forensic Sc., Environmental Science, Data Science

Other Bachelors Programmes
B.Com · BBA* · BCA* · BSW · BBA*
(Tourism & Hospitality Management) with an option to choose ACCA or CMA Course
*AICTE approved

M.Sc. Programmes
Chemistry, Physics Mathematics, Biochemistry Computer Sc., Criminology & Forensic Sc., Psychology, Food Science & Nutrition

M.A. Programmes
English, Economics, Journalism and Mass Communication

Other Programmes
M.Com · MSW · MCA* · MBA*
* AICTE approved programmes

SEPARATE HOSTEL FACILITY AVAILABLE FOR BOYS & GIRLS

Contact: Mob: 7022371285, 9741831619, 6364118983, 9008580707
e-mail: stphilos1946@gmail.com | Website: www.stphilos.ac.in

For the season of cold, men's closets get bold

Velvet blazers and brocade jackets light up the men's party scene. Bold colours and jewel tones create stunning silhouettes for winter soirees

Ranita.Ray
@timesofindia.com

Mysuru's foggy Christmas Eve is warming up, and the men in the city are going head-on to mesmerise the onlookers. As a fashion-forward man, get ready to stride into the party, velvet blazer catching neon glows, emerald silk shirt hugging your frame. Add a brocade jacket to whisper your style power. Heads turn: no more bland blacks or shivering usuals. Fashion experts from the industry visualise Indian men with an unmissable edge as temperatures drop. It's a season when jewel tones blaze, layers lock in warmth, and silhouettes slay. Gear up to own the night like never before. Here's how the city's sharpest men dominate with unmatched dressing swag.

HUES THAT COMMAND THE NIGHT

Deep emeralds lead the charge. Likewise, many swear by sacred purples evoking royal echoes, perfect for New Year toasts. "I have invested in the right pieces after watching the trends closely. For the NY eve, I am wearing a purple silk shirt and pairing it with matching trousers for a bold monochrome. A velvet blazer is part of the ensemble to add warmth," shares Dhruv Dutta, a marketing manager. One can also blend mustards, cosmic blues, with oyster greys for candlelit drama. Vibrant accents explode against black bases. Remember, slim silhouettes elongate your presence.

FABRICS, CUTS AND DESIGNS

Shrey Vij, founder of a luxury menswear brand, is excited about the December party season and the array of options men can try to put their best fashion foot forward. Vij says that this winter season, fabrics like lightweight fine worsted wool, cashmere, wool-cashmere blends, wool-silk blends, and velvets dominate partywear. "Want to look dapper? Go for tailored blazers with a slightly relaxed fit, double-breasted jackets and statement shackets. These pieces are trending, offering versatility for both formal and semi-formal settings," adds Vij.

Those who love to channel their style quotient through suits and tuxedos must remember that these pieces are moving beyond classic black into deep winter hues. "Consider experimenting with shades such as forest green, wine, and midnight blue. For festive and wedding occasions, winter-appropriate kurtas with stoles and shawls in textured fabrics, subtle embroideries and layered silhouettes are in focus, paired with Bandi jackets or tailored Bandhgalas for added warmth and polish," recommends Vij.

GO BY THE MUST-HAVES

If too many choices feel overwhelming, stick to the season's must-haves. Vij has some easy cues. "Invest in a versatile shacket or a cashmere blend bomber, a sharply tailored blazer or dress blazer if you need a bit of flair. Such pieces form the core of the modern man's party wardrobe this season, offering effortless versatility from intimate gatherings to extravagant festive celebrations."

OCCASION-PERFECT CHOICES

- **Dressy party:** Velvet jacket + shirt+ tie tack + Oxfords
- **Dinner somewhere between fancy and not:** Wool blazer + knit + loafers
- **House party:** Dark jeans + tailored jacket + pocket square

For men, there is quiet luxury, sharp tailoring and expressive details shaping winter partywear this season. Gopika G, faculty, at a Fashion Technology Institute, advises, "Take inspiration from collections by the world's leading fashion labels. They are rich with textures and loose silhouettes in fine wool, velvet, tweed, brushed cotton and knitted blends for A/W 26-27. Flowing suits, strong jackets, high-neck shirts, tailored trousers and dark denims are where it's at once again for every occasion." She also recommends, "Wardrobe builders make for easy styling clusters, and they can include tailored blazer, neutral trousers, fine-knit top or crisp shirt, deep denim and classic outerwear."

ACCESSORISING THAT ADDS POISE

It isn't just the apparel; men can add a dash of swank by accessorising. Gopika mentions that even simple accessories like pocket squares infuse a pop of colour, ties and tiepins make room for an otherwise minimal look to shine through. "Once you perfect it, then finish with loafers or Oxfords, depending on your mood. A classic watch, in gold for warmth or silver for modern minimalism, completes the look. These designs resemble what we see on the runway – all set to make winter party dressing equal parts confident and tailored, easygoing style," she shares.

Scanned with OKEN Scanner

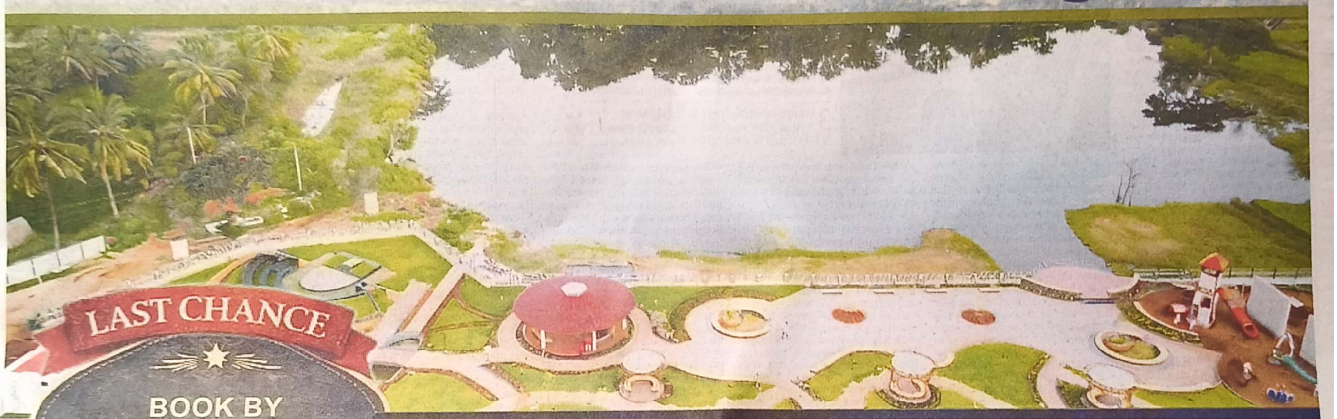
SAHA MEADOWS

ESS & ESS INFRASTRUCTURE PVT. LTD

Lakefront Plots Available Now

Valid From 24th - 31st DEc 2025

A Lake That Reflects Your Future. A Land That Grows Your Legacy.



LAST CHANCE

BOOK BY 31st DECEMBER 2025

FREE E-Khata

Clubhouse Membership For 20 Years

Terms and Conditions Apply

SAHA MEADOWS

Premium Lakefront Villa Plots, Mysuru

| 30x40 | 30x50 | 40×60 |

RERA NO: PRM/KA/RERA/1268/378/PR/210524/006916

Strategically Located Premium Layout in YANDAHALLI - Mysuru

Developed by - ESS & ESS INFRASTRUCTURE PVT. LTD.

20+ years of excellence | 121 landmark projects delivered | 28,000+ sites developed

LIMITED EAST-FACING PLOTS | BOOK YOUR SITE VISIT

www.essandess.in 9900898088 Mysuru

Scanned with OKEN Scanner